



Cannon and gunners are seen in this 17th-century painting commemorating the actions of the royalist forces in defeating the Fronde uprising in France.

THE DEATH OF LOUIS XIII in May 1643 had brought to the French throne the **four-year old Louis XIV**, under the regency of his mother, Anne of Austria (in direct defiance of Louis XIII's will). Whatever France's successes in the Thirty Years' War (see 1635) and its emerging supremacy over Spain, the country was not only **strapped for cash**, it had to confront continuing **peasant uprisings** brought about by harvest failures and punitive **demands for tax**. In addition, those nobles that Cardinal Richelieu (see 1624) had excluded from government were invited back to counter those supporters of Richelieu who were hostile to Anne and her new chief minister, Cardinal Mazarin (1602–61). Bungled attempts to

“DO YOU NOT KNOW, MY SON, WITH WHAT **LITTLE WISDOM THE WORLD IS GOVERNED?**”

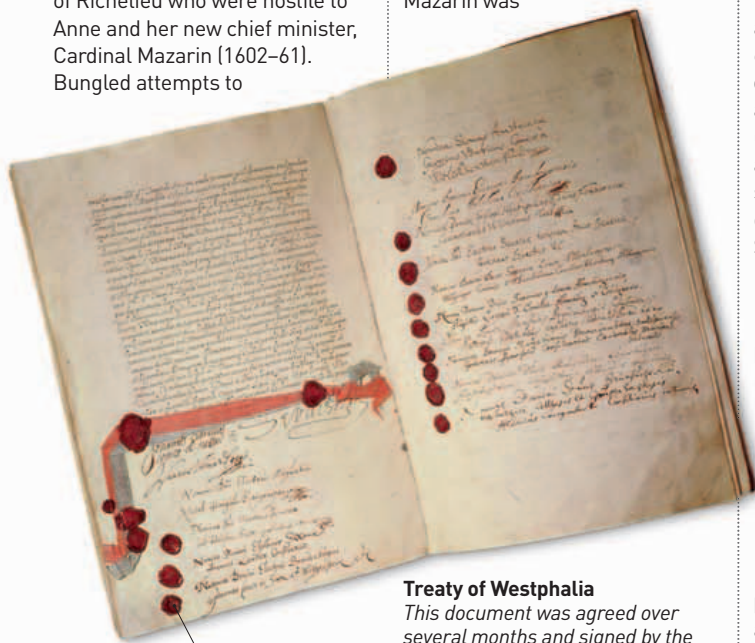
Axel Oxenstierna, Swedish chancellor, Westphalia, 1648

manage factional rivalries while maintaining a costly war were to lead to government breakdown in 1648 with the **Fronde**—initially a parliamentary protest, but later an **aristocratic uprising**. Four years of turmoil followed: Paris was taken, the royal family fled, and Mazarin was

twice forced into exile. When it fizzled out in 1652, the way lay open to a better management of aristocratic loyalties that was to come with the personal rule of Louis XIV from 1661.

In October 1648, after four years of negotiations, the **Thirty Years' War** in Germany was brought to a close with a series of treaties collectively known as the **Treaty of Westphalia**. France was still at war with Spain (as it would be until 1659), but Germany's horrors at least had been ended. France secured rather vaguely defined gains on its eastern border; Sweden was confirmed in its possession of Pomerania on the Baltic coast, as well as receiving a huge cash payment from the **Holy Roman Emperor**, Ferdinand III, to withdraw its troops. Among the German states, **Brandenburg-Prussia** gained the most.

Crucially, Spain also recognized the independence of the Dutch Republic, and Germany's local rulers were given the right to make **alliances with foreign powers**, in effect confirming them as sovereign states. The authority of the Holy Roman Emperor appeared **fatally undermined**.



seal of one of 109 parties

Treaty of Westphalia
This document was agreed over several months and signed by the Holy Roman Emperor and the king of France, ending 30 years of war.



This depiction of the execution of King Charles I of England outside the Banqueting House, in London, was painted by English artist John Weesop.

ON JANUARY 30, 1649, Charles I of England was beheaded. He remains the only **king of England** to have been **legally executed**. His conviction by the High Court of Justice as “tyrant, traitor, and murderer” was carried by a vote of 68 to 67. Throughout his trial, Charles consistently rejected any idea that any court could legally try a king. “I would know by what power I am called hither... Remember I am your King, your lawful King.” In reality, there is little doubt that since the triumph of the parliamentary New Model Army, **dominated by Oliver Cromwell**, his death became a possible outcome to the crisis. The awkward question was whether one form of tyranny was being swapped for another. Nonetheless, what counted was the assertion that a body of law



Dahomey panther mask
This bronze pendant in the shape of a stylized head of a panther, dating from 17th-century Dahomey, shows the country's cultural sophistication.



Oliver Cromwell
This portrait of Oliver Cromwell, the chief instigator of the trial and execution of the king, was painted by English artist Robert Walker.

separate from the person of the king existed that no one, legal ruler or not, could disregard: **Parliament, not the king, was the law's rightful custodian**.

At the end of the 1640s, the **Kingdom of Dahomey** began to emerge as a **powerful force** under King Wegbeja (d. 1685). After uniting the lands of the Aja and the Fon, he introduced new laws, **reformed government** and bureaucracy, and initiated a religion and culture that would characterize this **West African state** for more than two centuries.

January Khmelnytsky Uprising (to 1651): Ukrainian Cossacks seek independence from Poland-Lithuania

January 17 Long Parliament breaks off negotiations with Charles I, leading to **Second English Civil War**

October 24 Treaty of Westphalia ends Thirty Years' War in Germany

April Portuguese defeat Dutch army in Brazil

Russian serfs lose rights; anti-tax risings in Moscow

September 12 Battle of Stirling fought during Scottish Civil War

January 30 Eighty Years' War between Dutch and Spanish ends

The Fronde, a French aristocratic rebellion against Cardinal Mazarin, begins (to 1652)

Mughals transfer imperial court to Shahjahanabad (Delhi)

Ottomans besiege Venetian-held Crete

Russian explorer Semyon Dezhnev (1605–72) discovers Bering Strait

December 11 Pride's Purge expels majority from England's Long Parliament, creating Rump Parliament

January 30, 1649 Charles I of England executed (b. 1600)

May 1649 Commonwealth and Free State of England declared

September 1649 Siege of Drogheda, Ireland, by Oliver Cromwell

1649 Religious toleration guaranteed in Maryland, attracting many new settlers

1650 Portuguese retake Angolan coast from Dutch but lose Swahili ports to sultan of Oman

1650 Sa'di dynasty, Morocco, wanes, as Berbers challenge

1650 Dahomey emerges as powerful West African state